Q+A

Comedy Meets **Crime**

In* Inspector Zende *and beyond, actor MANOJ BAJPAYEE stays true to the core of his characters



Q. You get to show off your funny bone in Netflix's *Inspector Zende*. Do you enjoy comedy?

The narrative isn't serious even as it deals with the pursuit of a serial killer. The police are pygmies in front of him. They are dealing with too many odds, which lends itself to humour and irony. When you get into the skin of the character, you try to find moments of confusion, which for others may seem comic.

Q. They say imitation is flattery. Tell us about your approach to playing a real-life figure.

It was simple: I am dealing with a middle-class character. He is struggling in his day-to-day life, but he has the tenacity to persevere. Once I cracked that, everything became easy. Zende loves to talk. He told me of his moments of insecurity, his fears.

Q. Some of your finest work has been with Ram Gopal Varma—*Satya*, *Kaun*, *Shool*—and your next is a horror comedy with him.

I'll add here that if he gives me even a miniscule part, I'll do it. I was majorly surprised with the passion with which he was dealing with the film. The first schedule has completely shocked me. This man is back and I'm serious when I say that he will surprise everyone and make them eat their words.

Q. Your collaborations with independent filmmakers continue with Raam Reddy's *Jugnuma – The Fable*, currently playing in cinemas.

We do bad films, good films and fantastic films, but there are few great films. For me, *Jugnuma* is a great film. It redefines cinema and magical realism in a unique way. I have learned a lot from Raam and the character who is torn between attachment and detachment in life.

—with Suhani Singh

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH